

Summary

GNOME Do

Rating: 4 out of 5

The good

- Simple two-pane UI
- Largest plug-in library
- Powerful search, including content from even Tomboy notes

The bad

- Some plugins are complex to use and require a particular syntax
- Lack of notification tray icon

Website: <http://cooperteam.net/>

GNOME Pie

Rating: 3.5 out of 5

The good

- Innovative great looking UI
- Ability to use both mouse and keyboard for navigation
- Many theme options

The bad

- Lack of search capabilities
- No plug-in library

Website: http://www.simonschneegans.de/?page_id=12

Synapse

Rating: 4 out of 5

The good

- Simple intuitive UI
- Powerful search with full Zeitgeist integration
- Decent plug-in library

The bad

- Some plugins are complex to use
- Only six theme options

Website: <https://launchpad.net/synapse-project>

And the winner of this Software Showdown is...Synapse!

someone without knowing much about the person, I would suggest Synapse. It provides sufficient features for most users and its theme-able UI is extremely intuitive.

Epilogue: The end of application launchers?

While researching Synapse for this article, I chanced upon an interesting post at a site called 'Tech Drive-in'. It claimed that the launcher was not being maintained any more. Looking at the project's Launchpad page, I realised the latest version was about a year old. I asked a question on the same page but got no answer. I can only hope the project is being maintained.

Even GNOME Do hasn't been updated in a long time. Seeing this, a user asked about the project's status. Here's how Christopher Halse Rogers, the current project lead of Do, responded, "It's not dead, but it is reasonably mature, and

I don't have a lot of time to work on it at the moment."

With the introduction of Unity, many Ubuntu users have questioned the need for application launchers. What do you think? Are app launchers doomed? I would love to hear your responses at the poll on my blog.

On a more positive note, Simon Schneegans, the creator of GNOME Pie, is busy working on its successor—OpenPie. According to Schneegans, OpenPie will work on touch devices. Maybe that will be the future form of application launchers, just so long as it's open source. 

References

- [1] <http://www.techdrivein.com/2012/04/synapse-launcher-is-not-maintained.html>
- [2] <http://tusharbhargava.wordpress.com/2013/06/21/the-end-of-application-launchers/>

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